

LX-001

How to Cold Email a Law Firm (And Actually Get a Reply)

Audience: Students | Stage: Before You Apply | Read Time: 6 min

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01

Why most cold emails fail

The average law firm partner receives dozens of internship requests every week. Most get deleted within seconds — not because the sender isn't qualified, but because the email reads like a mass-produced template. Generic subject lines like "Internship Application" or "Seeking Internship Opportunity" signal zero effort.

The biggest mistakes are writing about yourself instead of the firm, attaching a CV without context, and sending the same email to 50 firms. Partners can tell. If your email doesn't show that you've researched the firm and understand what they do, it's going straight to trash.

The good news? Because most students get this wrong, even a slightly personalised email stands out dramatically. The bar is low — you just need to clear it.

02

Finding the right contact

Never send a cold email to "info@firmname.com" or a generic HR address. These go into a black hole. Instead, find the specific person who would supervise interns in the practice area you're interested in.

Start with the firm's website — most list their team with designations and practice areas. Look for Senior Associates or Partners in your target practice area. LinkedIn is your next best tool: search for "[Firm Name] Associate" and filter by location. Alumni networks are gold — if someone from your college works at the firm, that's your strongest entry point.

If you can't find a direct email, most Indian law firms follow predictable patterns: `firstname.lastname@firm.com` or `firstname@firm.com`. Tools like Hunter.io can help verify these.

03

Writing the subject line

Your subject line is the gatekeeper. It determines whether your email gets opened or ignored. Keep it specific, professional, and under 8 words.

Good examples: "3rd Year NLIU Student — Corporate Internship Query" or "Internship Application: IP Practice, June 2025." Bad examples: "Internship Application" or "Request for Internship Opportunity at Your Esteemed Firm."

The formula that works: [Year & College] + [Practice Area] + [Purpose]. This tells the reader exactly who you are and what you want before they even open the email.

04

The email structure

Keep your email under 150 words. Lawyers are busy — respect their time. Use this four-part structure:

Opener (1 sentence): State who you are and why you're writing. "I'm a 3rd year student at [College] interested in a [duration] internship with your [practice area] team."

Hook (2-3 sentences): Show you've done your research. Reference a specific case the firm handled, an article the partner wrote, or a recent deal they closed. This is what separates you from everyone else.

Credentials (2 sentences): Briefly mention your most relevant qualification — a moot court win, a relevant research paper, or prior internship experience. Don't list everything; pick the one thing that makes you right for this firm.

Close (1 sentence): A clear, low-pressure ask. "Would you be open to a brief conversation about potential internship opportunities?" Attach your CV but don't make the email about it.

05

Following up

If you don't hear back within 5-7 business days, send exactly one follow-up. Not two, not three — one. The follow-up should be even shorter than your original email.

Keep the same email thread (don't start a new one). Say something like: "I wanted to follow up on my earlier email. I remain very interested in the opportunity to intern with your team. I'd be happy to share any additional information that might be helpful."

If you still don't hear back, move on. Silence is a response. Don't take it personally — it almost never means your email was bad. Partners are genuinely busy, and sometimes the timing just isn't right. Apply to your next target and keep going.